Optimization Methods – Notes

Francesco Passino

Contents

1 Lesson 1 – Convex Analysis **2**

2 Lesson 2 – more about convex analysis **2**
2.1 Example on balls . . . 2
2.2 Operation that preserve convexity . . . 3
2.3 Relative interior . . . 3

3 Lesson 3 — cones and convex functions **4**
3.1 Convex functions . . . 4

4 Lesson 05 — 08/10/2026 **6**
4.1 Optimality conditions . . . 7
4.1.1 Existence of global optima for unconstrained quadratic programming problems . . . 8
4.2 Unconstrained optimization methods . . . 8
4.2.1 Gradient method . . . 9

5 Lesson 06 — 09/10/2026 **9**
5.1 Gradient method — quadratic case . . . 9
5.2 Inexact version of gradient methods . . . 9

1 Lesson 1 – Convex Analysis

Definition 1.1 (Convex set)**.**
A set C is *convex* if, for every $x, y \in C$ and every $\alpha \in [0,1]$,

$$\alpha x + (1-\alpha)y \in C.$$

Definition 1.2 (Affine set)**.**
A set C is *affine* if, for every $x, y \in C$ and every $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\alpha x + (1-\alpha)y \in C.$$

Remark. Every affine set is convex, since $[0,1] \subset \mathbb{R}$.

Example of affine set are: any single point, any line, the solution set of a linear system

Definition 1.3 (convex combination)**.**
A *convex combination* of the point $x^1, x^2, \ldots, x^k$ is a point

$$y = \sum_{i=1}^{k} \alpha_i x^i \quad \text{where} \quad \alpha_1, \ldots, \alpha_k \in [0,1] \quad \text{and} \quad \sum_{i=1}^{k} \alpha_i = 1$$

Remark. By definition, a set $C \in R^n$ is *convex* id it contains all the convex combinations of any two points in C.

A convex set also contain any convex combination of its points.

Lemma 1.4.
if C is convex, then any $x^1, \ldots, x^k \in C and \alpha_i, \ldots, \alpha_k \in [0,1] s.t. \sum_{i=1}^{k} \alpha_i = 1$,

$$\sum_{i=1}^{k} \alpha_i x^i \in C$$

Definition 1.5 (convex hull)**.**
The *convex hull* $conv(C)$ of a set C is the intersection of all teh convex sets containing C.
$\implies$ it is the smallest convex set containing C

Lemma 1.6.
$conv(C) = \{all\ convex\ combinatoins\ of\ points\ in\ C\}$

Remark. Observe tha C is convex if and only $C = conv(C)$

polyhedron and balls, !ToDo

2 Lesson 2 – more about convex analysis

2.1 Example on balls

we start the lesson by giving some example of balls exercise 1.1 find the unit ball $B(0,1)$ w.r.t $\|.\|_1, \|.\|_\infty \text{and} \|.\|_A where$

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

$\|x\|_1 = |x_1| + |x_2| \quad B(1,0) = \{(x_1, x_2) : \|x\|_1 \leq 1\} \implies |x_1| + |x_2| \leq 1$

$$|x_1| + |x_2| = \begin{cases} x_1 + x_2 \\ x_1 - x_2 \\ x_2 - x_1 \\ -x_1 - x_2 \end{cases}$$

These four equations need to be all less or equal then 1 so they draw a square rotated by 45 degrees intercepting 1 or-1 on the axis, that is our Ball and it is a convex set.

ToDo ∞

Now if we consider A norm.

$\|x\|_A = \sqrt{x^t AX}$

$x^t Ax = \begin{bmatrix} x_1 & x_2 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \end{bmatrix} = 4{x_1}^2 + {x_2}^2 \leq 1$ That's an ellipse

Exercise 2:
Prove that $B(0,1) = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n : \|x\| \leq 1\}$is convex for any norm
Let $x, y \in B(0,1)$, I have to prove that$\alpha x + (1-\alpha)y \in B(0,1), \quad \forall \alpha \in [0,1]$
$\implies \|\alpha x + (1-\alpha)y\| \leq 1 \quad \forall \alpha \in [0,1]$
$\|\alpha x + (1-\alpha)y\| \leq \|\alpha x\| + \|(1-\alpha)y\| = \alpha \|x\| + (1-\alpha)\|y\| \leq \alpha * 1 + (1-\alpha) * 1 = 1$

2.2 Operation that preserve convexity

Algebraic operations:

Lemma 2.1.
If $C_1 and C_2$ are convex, then $C_1 + C_2 \doteq \{x + y : x \in C_1, y \in C_2\}$ is convex.
If $C_1 and C_2$ are convex, then $C_1 - C_2 \doteq \{x - y : x \in C_1, y \in C_2\}$ is convex.

Topological operations:

Lemma 2.2.
if C is ocnvex then$cl(C)$is convex. if C is ocnvex then$int(C)$is convex, provided that $int(C) \neq \emptyset$.

2.3 Relative interior

Given a set $C \subseteq R^n$ we denote by $aff(C)$ teh smallest affine set containing C.

Definition 2.3 (Relative interior)**.**
Let $C \subseteq R^n$ be a convex set.
The relative interior of C is define by

$$ri(C) = \{x \in C : \exists \epsilon > 0 \ s.t. \ aff(C) \cap B(x, \epsilon) \subset C \subseteq\}$$

convex cone ToDo

3 Lesson 3 — cones and convex functions

Definition 3.1 (cone)**.**
A set C is a *cone* if, for every $x \in C$ and every $\lambda \geq 0$,

$$\lambda x \in C.$$

In other words, if C contains a point x different from 0, then it also contains the whole half-line starting at 0 and passing through x.
Cone may be convex or non-convex, let's see some examples of cones:

Example 3.2.
Here are some examples of cones:

- $\mathbb{R}^n_+$ is a convex cone.
- $\{\boldsymbol{x} \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x_1 x_2 = 0\}$ is a non-convex cone.
- Given a polyhedron $P = \{\boldsymbol{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n : A\boldsymbol{x} \leq \boldsymbol{b}\}$, the recession cone of P is the set

  $$\text{rec}(P) = \{\boldsymbol{d} \in \mathbb{R}^n : \boldsymbol{x} + \alpha \boldsymbol{d} \in P \text{ for any } \boldsymbol{x} \in P, \alpha \geq 0\}$$

  This gives us the set of directions that allow us to remain in the polyhedron. It's possible to demonstrate that this is a convex set.
- Given $\bar{x} \in cl(C) \subseteq R^n$, the set

  $$T_c(\bar{x}) = \{d \in R^n : \exists\{z_k\} \subset C, \exists\{t_k\} > 0, \lim_{k\to\infty} t_k(z_k - \bar{x}) = d\} is the tangent cone of C.$$

3.1 Convex functions

Definition 3.3.
A function f its convex , for every two points $x, y \in dom(f)$ and every $\alpha \in [0, 1]$,

$$f(\alpha y + (1-\alpha)x) \leq \alpha f(y) + (1-\alpha) f(x)$$

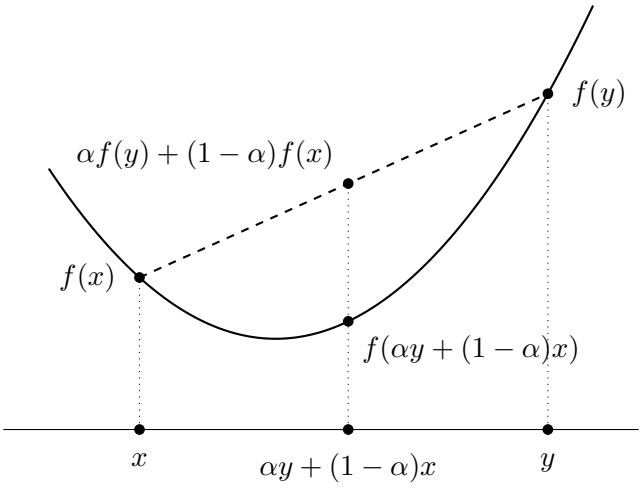


Figure 1: Example of a convex function.

Theorem 3.4.
A function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is convex if and only if the set,

$$\{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R} : y \geq f(x)\}$$

called the epigraph *of f, is convex.*

Definition 3.5 (concave function)**.**
Given a convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$, a function $f : R^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is concave on C if $-f$ is convex on C.

There are some functions that are both convex and concave, like a linear (affine) function $f(x) = C^t x + b$.

Theorem 3.6.
Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ be convex on the convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$. then f is continuous on the interior of C.

Definition 3.7 (strictly convex function)**.**
Givena a convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$, a function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is strictly convex on C if,

$$f(\alpha y + (1 - \alpha)x) < \alpha f(y) + (1 - \alpha)f(x)$$

for all $x, y \in C$, $x \neq y$, and $\alpha \in (0, 1)$. The difference between convex and strictly convex functions is that the inequality is strict for strictly convex functions, that means that a stictly convex function cannot be concave.

Definition 3.8 (strongly convex function)**.**
Given a convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$, a function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is strongly convex on C if there exists a constant $\tau > 0$ such that,

$$f(\alpha y + (1 - \alpha)x) \leq \alpha f(y) + (1 - \alpha)f(x) - \frac{\tau}{2}\alpha(1 - \alpha)\|y - x\|_2^2$$

Remark. Similarly to convex functions, we can define strictly or strongly concave functions f if $-f$ is strictly or strongly convex.

Theorem 3.9.
f is strongly convex if and only if $\exists \tau > 0$ such that $f(x) - \frac{\tau}{2}\|x\|_2^2$ is convex.

Remark. Thanks to this theorem we can say that f is strongly convex if and only if there exists a convex function g and a constant $\tau > 0$ such that $f(x) = g(x) + \frac{\tau}{2}\|x\|_2^2$.

If we consider a function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ that is differentiable on an open convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ we can use this theorem.

Theorem 3.10.
f is convex on C if and only if:

$$f(y) \geq f(x) + (y - x)^T \nabla f(x) \quad \forall x, y \in C$$

if we consider a function $g(y) = f(\bar{x}) + (y - \bar{x})^T \nabla f(\bar{x})$ we can see that this function is the tangent plane to the function f in the point $\bar{x}$, so this theorem says that a function is convex if and only if it is always above its tangent line.
We can also use the same theroem to ddefine strictly and strongly convex functions, we just need to change the inequality sign in the definition of convexity, for strictly convex functions, and add the term $\frac{\tau}{2}\|y - x\|_2^2$ for strongly convex functions.

Theorem 3.11.
t

- *f is strictly convex on C if and only if:*

$$f(y) > f(x) + (y-x)^T \nabla f(x) \quad \forall x, y \in C, x \neq y$$

- *f is strongly convex on C if and only if:*

$$f(y) \geq f(x) + (y-x)^T \nabla f(x) + \frac{\tau}{2}\|y-x\|_2^2 \quad \forall x, y \in C$$

If we can evaluate the second order derivative of a function $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ we can use the following theorem.

Theorem 3.12.
Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ be a twice differentiable function on an open convex set $C \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$. Then:

- *f is convex on C if and only if for all $x \in C$ the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 f(x)$ is positive semidefinite*

$$v^T \nabla^2 f(x) v \geq 0 \quad \forall v \in \mathbb{R}^n, \forall x \in C,$$

  or, equivalently, the eigenvalues of $\nabla^2 f(x)$ are non-negative for all $x \in C$.

- *if $\nabla^2 f(x)$ is positive definite for all $x \in C$, then f is strictly convex on C.*

- *f is strongly convex on C if and only if there exists a constant $\tau > 0$ such that $\nabla^2 f(x) - \tau I_n$ is positive semidefinite for all $x \in C$.*

$$v^T \nabla^2 f(x) v \geq \tau \|v\|_2^2 \quad \forall v \in \mathbb{R}^n, \forall x \in C,$$

  or, equivalently, the eigenvalues of $\nabla^2 f(x)$ are greater than or equal to τ for all $x \in C$.

4 Lesson 05 — 08/10/2026

Theorem 4.1.
Assume that f is convex on the convex set X. Then ***any local optimum of (P) is a global optimum****.*

Proof. Let x^* be a local optimum of (P), i.e., there is $r > 0$ s.t.

$$f(x^*) \leq f(z) \quad \forall z \in X \cap B(x^*, r).$$

Continue on slide. □

Proposition 4.2.
Assume that f is ***strictly convex*** *on the convex set X and that (P) admits a global optimum x^*. Then x^* is the* ***unique*** *optimal solution of (P).*

Theorem 4.3.
If $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}$ is strongly convex on $\mathbb{R}^n$ and X is closed, then there exists a global optimum.

Corollary 4.4.
If f is strongly convex (on $\mathbb{R}^n$) and X is closed and convex, then there exists a unique global optimum.

Example 4.5.
Any quadratic programming problem

$$\min \frac{1}{2}x^T Qx + c^T x, \quad x \in X,$$

where Q is a `positive definite` matrix and X is closed and convex, has a unique global optimum.

If Q is positive definite, all its eigenvalues are bounded below by a strictly positive constant $\implies$ f is strongly convex.

4.1 Optimality conditions

We now focus on optimality conditions for unconstrained problems.

Theorem 4.6 (Necessary optimality condition)**.**
Assume that X is an open set and let f be differentiable at $x^* \in X$. If x^* is a local optimum of (P), then

$$\nabla f(x^*) = 0.$$

From now on, assume that f has continuous first and second order partial derivatives for every $x \in X$.

Theorem 4.7 (Second order necessary optimality condition)**.**
Let X be an open set and let $x^* \in X$ be a local optimum for (P). Then the following conditions hold:

- $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$;
- *the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 f(x^*)$ is positive semidefinite.*

Theorem 4.8 (Second order sufficient optimality condition)**.**
Let X be an open set, $x^* \in X$, and assume that the following conditions hold:

- $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$;
- *the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 f(x^*)$ is positive definite.*

Then x^* is a local optimum for (P).

Theorem 4.9 (Optimality condition for convex problems)**.**
Let f be a differentiable convex function on the open convex set X. Then $x^* \in X$ is a global optimum for (P) if and only if $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$.

Proof. The necessity follows from the necessary optimality condition. It's important to prove the converse implication. If $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$, we can prove it by applying the first order condition for convex functions with $y = x^*$:

$$f(x) - f(x^*) \geq (x - x^*)^T \nabla f(x^*) = 0 \quad \forall x \in X.$$

□

Theorem 4.10.
Let f be a differentiable strictly convex function on the open convex set X. Then $x^* \in X$ is

the unique global optimum for (P) if and only if $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$.

4.1.1 Existence of global optima for unconstrained quadratic programming problems

Consider the problem

$$\min f(x) := \frac{1}{2}x^T Q x + c^T x, \quad x \in \mathbb{R}^n, \tag{P}$$

where Q *is an* $n \times n$ *symmetric matrix.*

Corollary 4.11.
There exists a global optimum x^* *for (P) if and only if the following conditions hold:*

(i) $Qx^* + c = 0$*;*

(ii) Q *is positive semidefinite.*

Condition (i) is the same as $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$ *(first order condition). Condition (ii) is the second order condition (*Q *is the Hessian of* f*).*

Remark. We already observed that if Q is positive definite, then (P) admits a unique global optimum. Its expression is $x^* = -Q^{-1}c$, derived from condition (i).

If Q *is positive semidefinite but not positive definite, in order to guarantee the existence of a global optimum we need to analyze the existence of solutions of the system* $Qx + c = 0$ *using the Rouché–Capelli theorem.*

4.2 Unconstrained optimization methods

We will see some methods for optimization problems. What is an optimization methods? In an optimization descent methods we want to find a sequence of point $x^0, x^1, \dots, x^k, \dots$ *such that* $f(x^0) > f(x^1) > \dots f(x^k) > \dots$ *and we would like that* $\lim_{k\to\infty} x^k = x^*$ *where* x^* *is such that* $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$ *so it's a stationary points.*

A descent methods is characterize by the fact that $x^{k+1} = x^k + td^k$ *where* d^k *is a descent direction for* f *at* x^k *and* $t > 0$ *is the* `step`*.*

Definition 4.12 (descent direction)**.**
$d \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is a descent direction for f at x^k if we have that $d^T \nabla f(x^k) < 0$.

This means that the directional derivative along the direction d *is strictly negative. For a suitable* t *sufficiently small we have that* f *of* $f(x^{k+1}) < f(x^k)$*.*

How to find a descent direction? We need to solve $\min d^t \nabla f(x^k)$ *where the* $\|d\| = 1$*. In other words we want to find the steepest direction of descent. Recall that* $d^t \nabla f(x^k) = \|d\| \left\|f(x^k)\right\| \cos(\theta)$ *where* θ *is the angle between the gradient and the descent direction. To minimize that we need to minimize the cosine of* θ *(-1). So the solution to the min problem is* $d^k = -\frac{\nabla f(x^k)}{\|\nabla f(x^k)\|}$*. This is also known as the* `Gradient method`*.*

Algorithm 1: Gradient method

Choose $x^0 \in \mathbb{R}^n$, set $k = 0$;
while $\nabla f(x^k) \neq 0$ **do**
  $d^k = -\nabla f(x^k)$; // search direction
  compute an optimal solution t_k of $\min_{t>0} f(x^k + td^k)$; // step size
  $x^{k+1} = x^k + t_k d^k$;
  $k = k + 1$;

4.2.1 Gradient method

5 Lesson 06 — 09/10/2026

5.1 Gradient method — quadratic case

If $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^T Qx + c^T x$, with Q a positive definite matrix, we can use the Taylor expansion at x^k:

$$f(x^k + td^k) = f(x^k) + (td^k)^T \nabla f(x^k) + \frac{1}{2}(td^k)^T Q\, td^k = \frac{1}{2}(d^k)^T Q d^k\, t^2 + (d^k)^T g^k\, t + f(x^k),$$

where $g^k = \nabla f(x^k) = Qx^k + c$. Now we want to minimize this expression with respect to t: we take the derivative with respect to t, set it equal to 0 and solve for t:

$$t_k = -\frac{(d^k)^T g^k}{(d^k)^T Q d^k}.$$

As already observed, two subsequent directions are orthogonal: $(d^k)^T d^{k+1} = 0$. This implies that the generated sequence has a zig-zag behavior, which can result in slow convergence.

Theorem 5.1 (Error bound)**.**
If $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^T Qx + c^T x$, with Q a positive definite matrix, and x^* is the global minimum of f, then the sequence $\{x^k\}$ satisfies the following inequality:

$$\left\|x^{k+1} - x^*\right\|_Q \leq \left(\frac{\frac{\lambda_n}{\lambda_1} - 1}{\frac{\lambda_n}{\lambda_1} + 1}\right) \left\|x^k - x^*\right\|_Q \quad \forall k \geq 0, \qquad \textit{(linear convergence)}$$

where $\|x\|_Q = \sqrt{x^T Qx}$ and $0 < \lambda_1 \leq \lambda_2 \leq \cdots \leq \lambda_n$ are the eigenvalues of Q.

Remark. If λ_n/λ_1 (the *condition number* of Q) is $\gg 1$, then the ratio

$$\frac{\frac{\lambda_n}{\lambda_1} - 1}{\frac{\lambda_n}{\lambda_1} + 1} \simeq 1$$

and the convergence may be slow.

The convergence rate is strictly related to the condition number of the matrix Q.

5.2 Inexact version of gradient methods

When f is not a quadratic function, finding the exact minimum along the direction may be computationally expensive, so in these cases we define a stopping condition on the step.

Algorithm 2: Gradient method with the Armijo inexact line search

Set $\alpha, \gamma \in (0,1)$ and $\bar{t} > 0$. Choose $x^0 \in \mathbb{R}^n$, set $k = 0$;
while $\nabla f(x^k) \neq 0$ **do**
  $d^k = -\nabla f(x^k)$, $t_k = \bar{t}$;
  while $f(x^k + t_k d^k) > f(x^k) + \alpha\, t_k (d^k)^T \nabla f(x^k)$ **do**
    $t_k = \gamma\, t_k$;
  $x^{k+1} = x^k + t_k d^k$;
  $k = k + 1$;